

How to Use Your Brain to Manage Pain

When we are in pain, the usual courses of action involve medical treatment or painkillers. However, we can also help control pain ourselves by regulating our mental response—both to the pain and to the stress it causes.

Pain is an emotional as well as physical response to injury or disease. Intense fear or anxiety are vital immediate reactions that cause you to avoid sources of pain whenever possible. Sometimes, however, pain persists even when the injury or disease is no longer present. A painful sensation can become associated with constant stress, recurring unpleasant memories of what caused the pain, or the constant fear that it will persist or recur.

These feelings can be powerful and unsettling. Although you should always seek medical advice if pain is severe or prolonged, you can also use several techniques to regulate it by training your mind.

The painkiller problem

Medication is often essential to control pain in the short term, but taking painkillers for an extended period can lead to issues such as addiction or serious physical side

effects, including stomach ulcers and liver disease. Your body may also build up a tolerance to a drug so that you derive less benefit from it as time goes on.

Mind-body therapies

In addition to medication, you can use mind-body techniques such as relaxation and visualization to reduce or help control pain—with no risk of side effects. Most use relaxation and deep, controlled breathing to reduce the tension that comes with pain and often makes it worse. Try lying quietly in a darkened room; breathe in deeply while counting to 10, hold the breath for a moment, then exhale slowly for a count of 10. Continue this for 10–20 minutes.

Shifting your attention often reduces pain's severity. Try turning your attention away from the painful area, focusing instead on a nonpainful part of your body. Alternatively, imagine the pain as

a big ball of energy outside your body, and “shrink” it in your mind. Cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) uses a similar approach, by training you to replace negative thoughts like “This pain is unbearable,” or “I can't stop this pain,” with positive ones such as, “This pain is only temporary.”

Practicing mindfulness reduces stress, making you better able to cope with pain. In this practice, adapted from Buddhist teachings, you merely acknowledge the pain—instead of allowing it to dominate your thoughts or exhausting yourself by actively fighting it.

To sum up, your brain can be a powerful tool for pain control if you:

- **Practice relaxation and deep breathing techniques to reduce stress levels.**
- **Employ mental exercises to shift attention away from pain.**
- **Use CBT techniques to focus on positive thoughts.**
- **Practice mindfulness.**